WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Child bride to Nari Shakti Puraskar awardee, Bina epitomises female enterprise with her mushroom business

Mushroom Mahila

In his feminist poem, *The Mushroom Hunters*, Neil Gaiman talks of how women were the first scientists, because while the men were out hunting, women would venture out, carrying babies in slings so that their hands could be free...to pick mushrooms. "*Some mushrooms will kill you/ while some will show you gods/and some will feed the hunger in our bellies....*"

Bina Devi, from the small hamlet of Tilkari in Bihar, will relate. She started growing mushrooms at home in 2014. By 2019, a 450 sq. ft shed had come up. In 2020, the enterprise earned her the title of Bihar's 'Mushroom Mahila' as well as that year's Nari Shakti Puraskar.

Bina was only 14 when she was married off to a farmer, Krishnakant. Money was tight, perhaps why, unlike other young brides, Bina joined her husband in the fields. Her hard work soon drew the admiration of her father-in-law, who affectionately began calling her 'Grihalaxmi', the one who brought prosperity to the house. Little did he know how prophetic the blessing would prove to be.

Bina was elected sarpanch in 2011. The next year, scientists from the Bihar Agricultural University visited Tilkari to train rural women in mushroom cultivation so that they could earn a livelihood. Bina soon mastered it, realising that "mushroom cultivation required little space, modest investment and could generate rich returns". The experiment transformed the family's fortunes, the additional income helping the family dream of a better future. Today, her four children are all well educated, with the youngest, a daughter, pursuing a Bachelor of Computer Applications. The family's old mud house is now much bigger. Nearby rises a concrete home in which Bina has invested nearly Rs 12 lakh.

But the achievement is also about teaching other women to dream. Today, women from a hundred villages earn a livelihood through mushroom farming under her guidance. Bina also travels across Bihar and even to other states to conduct training programmes. ■

—Amitabh Srivastava

HER TAKE

"Every woman—especially in rural India—should strive for financial independence. Become someone your children can look up to"

BINA DEVI, 49
Mushroom farmer
Tilkari, Bihar

RANJAN RAHI



Bina Devi, standing, with a bag of her mushrooms